THE SCHOOL EDUCATION MAKEOVER

FROM MORNING MEALS TO INTEGRATED CAMPUSES, THE REVANTH REDDY GOVERNMENT IS TRYING TO RESTORE FAITH IN GOVERNMENT SCHOOLS, THOUGH DELIVERY GAPS REMAIN

By Prasad Nichenametla *in Vikarabad district*



For a couple of years, 12-year-old Babu Vadde was known as the 'swooning boy' at the Mandal Parishad Upper Primary School in Kotbaspalle village in Telangana's Vikarabad district. He would faint from hunger in the hours before the midday meal, sometimes during morning assembly. Not anymore. The breakfast scheme introduced by the Revanth Reddy government in state-run schools at the start of this academic year has helped ease the morning hunger pangs and accompanying weakness among children like Babu. His friends say he looks healthier now. Reminded of his fainting spells, the Class VII student smiles sheepishly. "I can focus more on studies now," he says.

The Mandal Parishad school is among 1,269 schools where the scheme was launched in the first phase on June 15, when schools reopened after the summer break. An expansion of the pilot scheme introduced by Reddy's predecessor, K. Chandrashekar Rao, it is expected to reach all 26,000-odd schools and junior colleges across Telangana by the end of the year.

But breakfast is just one of a slew of initiatives the Congress government in Telangana has rolled out over the past two years. Chief Minister Reddy, who also holds the education portfolio, is determined to overhaul the state's education sector and leave a lasting imprint (see *Building Better Schools*). Last year, pre-primary education was introduced in government schools for the first time.

There is also a plan to vastly improve government day schools by introducing corporate-level infrastructure and pre-primary sections. In June, the Reddy government launched Telangana Public Schools (TGPS), with the aim of providing education on a par with the best-run private schools. The objective is to establish such schools in most of the state's 119 assembly constituencies, with English as the medium of instruction, facial recognition attendance systems, digital classrooms, upgraded science and computer labs, and opportunities for personality development. "Every student must be equipped to compete with the world," Reddy said at the launch of the first such school in Arutla, in Ranga Reddy district. "Quality education and nutritious food," he added, "must go hand in hand."

Another flagship initiative is the Young India Integrated Residential Schools (YIIRS). The schools are envisioned as institutions of social inclusion, marking a departure from the